

GIMP for Beginners

Part 1: User Interface



The GIMP is a great tool, but many of us don't even know how to get started with it. So let's get a grip on this powerful image manipulation tool, beginning with its user interface.

*T*he GIMP or the GNU Image Manipulation program is a free and open source raster image editing software. It is very powerful and a great alternative to Photoshop. It has always been denounced for an interface that's too perplexing for newbies.

I always wondered how people could be so good at creating wallpapers and editing images. I even asked them and tried Photoshop many a time. But its complexity always forced me to un-install it. One fine day, I installed Linux and started playing with the GIMP, as it was the default image editor. It wasn't long before I got used to it. I am still discovering uncovered facts and reaching newer shores with this tool. After I became comfortable with the GIMP, it was just a matter of time before I created a wallpaper, edited an image or any other work of art.

Now, allow me to guide you through the first leg of this tutorial where you will get introduced to a few basic facts about the interface, several basic editing tools, how to spice up photos, and other tips and tricks. Once we get these done, we will explore how to make wallpapers and designs with this image editor.

First, let me introduce you to the GIMP 2.6 interface and what those tools are meant for.

But before we get started, it is necessary to install the application (preferably, the latest version). The current stable version is 2.6.6 and it ensures that you are not affected by unwanted bugs. Every new Linux distribution comes with the GIMP 2.6 as the default image editing program. If you have an older

revision, you can update it using your package manager. If your operating system doesn't ship with it, head to www.gimp.org to find a binary installation package for your OS. Since the GIMP is a cross-platform software, it is available for nearly all the operating systems, ranging from Linux and Windows, to Mac OS and BSD. Thus, it shouldn't be a problem for you to get your binary package.

The interface

Once you have finished the installation, it's time to start the application. GIMP starts with a 'Splash Screen'; the initial loading can be a bit long depending on the system you use and the number of fonts and plug-ins installed. But this load time becomes much snappier from next time onwards.



Tips: You can change the splash screen by creating a 'splashes' directory in the *.gimp* folder.

- Linux: `~/gimp/splashes`
- Windows: `X:\Documents and Settings\username\gimp-2.6\splashes`

And copy the desired splash image with `gimp-splash.png` name

The default interface of the GIMP consists of three features:

1. **Toolbox:** This consists of tools and the tools option to perform several operations.
2. **Image Window:** This is the section where you